First Inaugural Address

President Franklin D. Roosevelt · March 4, 1933

Source: Franklin D. Roosevelt, First Inaugural Address (March 4, 1933), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.

Roosevelt took office at the depth of the Great Depression: nearly 25% unemployment, thousands of banks closed, industrial production cut in half. His first inaugural is remembered for the line 'the only thing we have to fear is fear itself' — but the speech also asked Congress for 'broad executive power' equivalent to wartime authority and laid the philosophical groundwork for the activist federal government of the New Deal.

Connect: FDR expanded federal power more than any president since Lincoln (Class 22). Compare their justifications — what does each say about when normal government is inadequate?

Key Passages

'Fear itself'

> This is preeminently the time to speak the truth, the whole truth, frankly and boldly. … So, first of all, let me assert my firm belief that the only thing we have to fear is fear itself—nameless, unreasoning, unjustified terror which paralyzes needed efforts to convert retreat into advance.

On the 'money changers'

> Primarily this is because the rulers of the exchange of mankind's goods have failed, through their own stubbornness and their own incompetence, have admitted their failure, and abdicated. Practices of the unscrupulous money changers stand indicted in the court of public opinion, rejected by the hearts and minds of men.

On 'wartime' executive power

> But in the event that the Congress shall fail to take one of these two courses, and in the event that the national emergency is still critical, I shall not evade the clear course of duty that will then confront me. I shall ask the Congress for the one remaining instrument to meet the crisis—broad Executive power to wage a war against the emergency, as great as the power that would be given to me if we were in fact invaded by a foreign foe.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The depth of the Great Depression: about 25% unemployment, bank failures, and widespread hunger and despair after three years of Hoover's limited response.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The American people listening on radio and in the crowd, and Congress, which would pass emergency legislation.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Franklin D. Roosevelt, a newly elected Democratic president who believed government action was needed to restore confidence and relieve suffering.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Historical Reasoning — Causation (1 pt): Write a thesis on the causes of the Great Depression that the New Deal was designed to address.
2. Identify ONE specific 'first 100 days' law that grew out of FDR's call here for emergency powers.
3. Compare FDR's tone with Hoover's 1928 speech. What changed between October 1929 and March 1933?